

Chapter 8: The Mongol Empire

Unit 2 • Ch. 8 • c. 1206–1368
AP World History: Modern

CUE COLUMN (cover & recall)

NOTES COLUMN (main content)

Genghis Khan & the Mongols

1206: Temujin unified as Genghis Khan at kurultai — begins conquest era

- Decimal military system (units of 10/100/1000/10,000) — meritocracy over tribal loyalty
- Psychological warfare: offer mercy to surrender; total destruction to resistance
- Yam postal relay system: communication across empire; also used by merchants
- Conquest was NOT random — targeted cities for wealth, skilled artisans captured not killed

Four Khanates (after Mongol split)

Yuan Dynasty (Kublai Khan, China): founded 1271; adopted Chinese governance; hosted Marco Polo

Ilkhanate (Persia/Middle East): founded 1256; sacked Baghdad 1258; later rulers converted to Islam

Golden Horde (Russia/W. steppes): Russian princes paid tribute for 200+ years → shaped Russian autocracy

Chagatai Khanate (Central Asia): controlled heart of Silk Roads; fragmented earliest

AP Exam: know which khanate controlled which region — questions test regional comparisons

Destruction & Pax Mongolica (the paradox)

DESTRUCTION: Baghdad sacked 1258 (House of Wisdom burned); Samarkand destroyed; millions killed

PAX MONGOLICA (~1250s–1340s): unified rule → safe travel → trade peaks

- Mongols PROFITED from taxing trade → rebuilt infrastructure they had destroyed
- Technology diffused: Chinese gunpowder → Persia → Europe; Persian astronomy → China

■ AP EXAM KEY: describe BOTH sides — never say Mongols were only destructive OR only beneficial

Key People & Their Significance

Genghis Khan: founder; military innovations as important as his conquests

Kublai Khan: Yuan Dynasty; adopted Chinese admin; received Marco Polo; failed to conquer Japan

Hulagu Khan: Ilkhanate; destroyed Baghdad 1258; ended Abbasid Caliphate

Timur (Tamerlane): 1370–1405; briefly reunified Central Asia; Timurid Renaissance; Babur's ancestor

Conquered peoples: captured artisans/scholars = forced migration of knowledge across Eurasia

The Black Death (Mongol connection)

Bubonic plague originated in Central Asian rodent populations c. 1330s

- Traveled WESTWARD along Mongol-enabled trade routes
- Siege of Caffa (1346): Mongols may have catapulted plague victims over walls → ships to Sicily
- Killed ~1/3 of Europe; comparable mortality in Middle East and China
- CONSEQUENCES: Yuan Dynasty weakened → collapses 1368; Ilkhanate already fragmented
- Same trade routes that enabled Pax Mongolica transmitted the plague — ultimate unintended consequence

Regional Impact comparison

China: Direct Mongol rule (Yuan); adopted Chinese bureaucracy; expelled 1368 (Ming); recovered well

Russia: Tributary (Golden Horde); Mongols did NOT directly administer; shaped autocratic tradition

Persia/Middle East: Direct Ilkhanate rule; Baghdad destroyed; later rulers converted to Islam

Europe: Repelled at Poland/Hungary 1241; indirectly affected by Black Death via trade routes

AP Exam: compare China vs. Russia — different types of Mongol control → different long-term effects

Long-term Legacy

- Yuan collapse 1368 → Ming Dynasty; Ming's policies (Great Wall, maritime withdrawal) react to Mongol trauma
- Timur (Tamerlane) → Timurid Renaissance → Mughal Empire (Babur = Timur's descendant)
- Gunpowder diffused westward via Mongol networks → Military Revolution → gunpowder empires (Unit 3)
- Silk Road decline after Mongol collapse → European search for maritime alternatives → Exploration
- Russian tribute to Golden Horde for 200+ years → shaped centralized autocratic political culture

AP Exam Tips Ch. 8

- ★ **The Mongol paradox is the MOST TESTED concept: simultaneous destruction + integration**
- TRAP: Never say 'the Mongols spread the plague intentionally' — unintended consequence
- TRAP: Don't say Mongol rule was the same everywhere — Yuan ≠ Golden Horde
- ↔ **COMPARE: China (direct rule, adapted admin) vs. Russia (tributary, less integration)**
- ✓ CHAIN: Conquest → Pax Mongolica → plague travels routes → Yuan/Ilkhanate collapse → maritime Era

SUMMARY — Write a 3-5 sentence synthesis in your own words:

The Mongol Empire (1206–1368) was simultaneously the most destructive and most connectivity-enabling force in the pre-modern world. Founded by Genghis Khan through military genius and organizational innovation, the empire's conquests destroyed Baghdad (1258), the Song Dynasty (1279), and countless Silk Road cities — but the resulting *Pax Mongolica* (c. 1250s–1340s) enabled unprecedented Eurasian exchange. The same trade networks carried gunpowder westward and Persian astronomy eastward, and also carried the bubonic plague, which killed roughly one-third of Europe by 1353. As Mongol political unity fragmented — Ilkhanate collapsed mid-14th century, Yuan Dynasty 1368 — the overland Silk Road lost its political infrastructure, driving merchants toward maritime routes and European states toward ocean exploration.

My summary in my own words:
